

The Vikings

No one living between the 8th and 11th centuries welcomed a visit from the Vikings. These wild seafarers from Scandinavia caused widespread terror with lightning raids and looting. But as bold explorers, they travelled far and opened up a wider world.

CLOTHING

Tunics and trousers for men and long dresses for women were usual Viking wear. Most clothes were made of wool or linen and animal skins. Only the rich could afford silks and fancy accessories. The women wove and sewed everything.



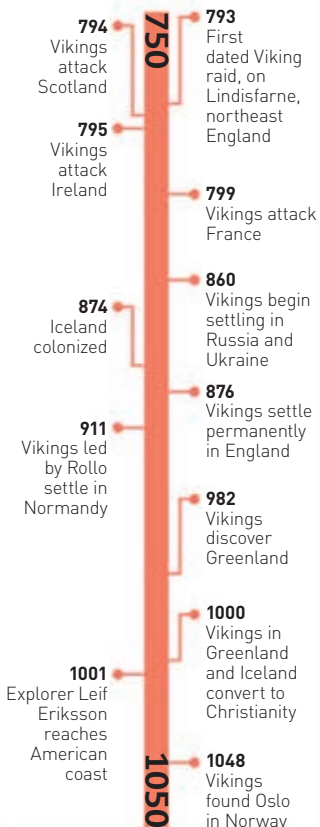
CHILD

MOTHER

MERCHANT

RAIDING RECORD

The 300-year Viking history is marked out by raids, voyaging, and the colonizing of new lands.



TREASURE

Every self-respecting Viking family had their special treasures. Rich folk prized finely crafted gold and silver jewellery. A typical adventurer, whether raider or trader, picked up ornaments and trophies in other lands.



JEWELS
Rock crystal beads set in silver.



GOLDSMITH'S ART
Intricate brooch of twisted gold wires.



GAMING PIECE
Amber figure used in a board game.



ARM BAND
Solid silver arm ring with moulded beading.



BUCKLED UP
Patterned buckle plate.



MINI CUP
Tiny silver cup with engraved pattern.



HUNTING HORN
Made from the horn of an ox.



"EASTER" EGG
Christian symbol of rebirth from Russia.



BURIAL CHEST
Decorated oak chest made for a ship burial.



LOKI
Shapeshifter and god of mischief.



ASK
First man, created from an ash tree.



ODIN
Norse god of wisdom and war.



THOR
Hammer-wielding god of thunder.



HEL
Goddess of the Underworld.

NORSE MYTHS

The ancient Norse myths explain how the world and the first people were created. The stories are full of dragons, magic, warring gods, and giants as wild as the Vikings themselves. According to Norse myth, there is a great battle still to come, which will end this world and start a new one.



RUNE ALPHABET

RUNES

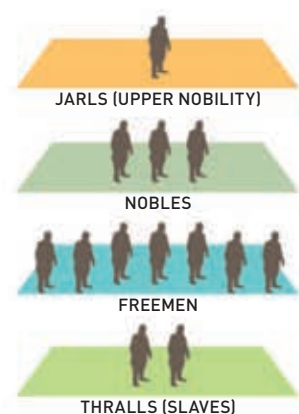
The Vikings used an alphabet of letters known as runes. These runes can be seen today carved into memorial stones, such as the famous Jelling Stones in Denmark, or as messages on pieces of wood and bone.

JELLING STONES
A copy showing pictures and runes.



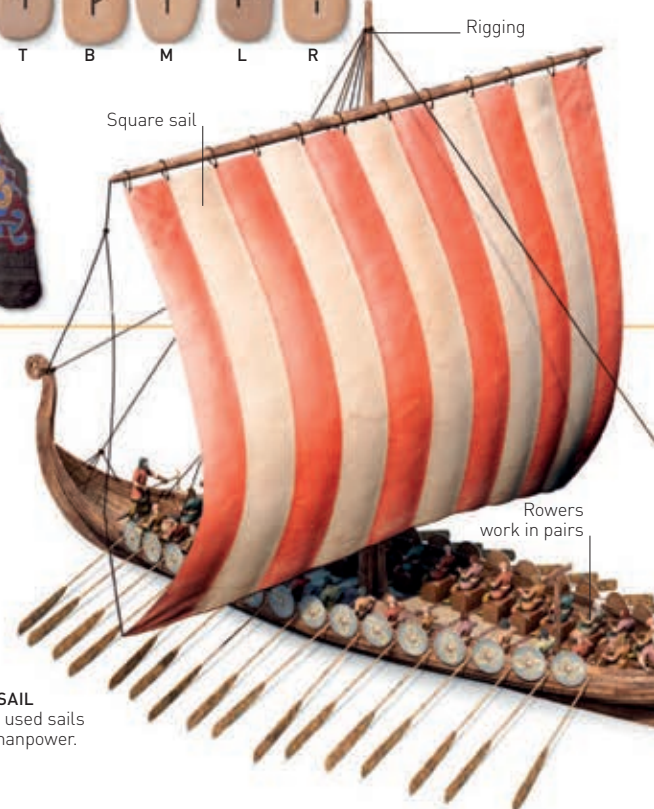
VIKING SOCIETY

At the top of the Viking social scale were the nobility, the uppermost being the jarls. Then came the freemen, such as warriors, craftsmen, and farmers. Lowest on the scale were slaves, or thralls, many of them prisoners of war.



FAR AND WIDE

The Vikings were skilled navigators. Sailing from what are now Denmark, Norway, and Sweden, they crossed open oceans in their small wooden boats. Their sea and land expeditions took them west to North America and east to Central Asia.



FULL SAIL
A Viking ship used sails as well as manpower.